

Adherence to healthy lifestyle habits in US adults, 1988-2006.

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BACKGROUND: Lifestyle choices are associated with cardiovascular disease and mortality. The purpose of this study was to compare adherence to healthy lifestyle habits in adults between 1988 and 2006. **METHODS:** Analysis of adherence to 5 healthy lifestyle trends (≥ 5 fruits and vegetables/day, regular exercise >12 times/month, maintaining healthy weight [body mass index 18.5-29.9 kg/m²], moderate alcohol consumption [up to 1 drink/day for women, 2/day for men] and not smoking) in the National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey 1988-1994 were compared with results from the National Health and Nutrition Examination Survey 2001-2006 among adults aged 40-74 years. **RESULTS:** Over the last 18 years, the percent of adults aged 40-74 years with a body mass index ≥ 30 kg/m² has increased from 28% to 36% ($P < .05$); physical activity 12 times a month or more has decreased from 53% to 43% ($P < .05$); smoking rates have not changed (26.9% to 26.1%); eating 5 or more fruits and vegetables a day has decreased from 42% to 26% ($P < .05$), and moderate alcohol use has increased from 40% to 51% ($P < .05$). Adherence to all 5 healthy habits has gone from 15% to 8% ($P < .05$). Although adherence to a healthy lifestyle was lower among minorities, adherence decreased more among non-Hispanic Whites over the period. Individuals with a history of hypertension/diabetes/cardiovascular disease were no more likely to be adherent to a healthy lifestyle than people without these conditions. **CONCLUSIONS:** Generally, adherence to a healthy lifestyle pattern has decreased during the last 18 years, with decreases documented in 3 of 5 healthy lifestyle habits. These findings have broad implications for the future risk of cardiovascular disease in adults.